Application of Group Process to Schools and Community Agency Settings

Part Three illustrates how group process concepts and practices are used in groups geared to the needs of particular client populations. Group leaders who work with children, adolescents, adults, and older adults each have special responsibilities. Guest contributors help us describe how to set up these specialized groups and share approaches that may be useful as you design your own groups. In planning and leading any of these special types of groups, leaders must have the necessary competence to facilitate them. In addition to the skills and knowledge about group process discussed in Chapter 2, group leaders must be familiar with the particular needs of the target population for a group.

Students in counseling and related programs are often required to complete an internship involving work with a variety of people: children or adolescents, college students, older adults, clients with substance use disorders, hospitalized patients, or outpatients in a community agency. As a mental health worker, you may be asked to set up and lead a variety of groups. Of course, not all of these specialized groups can be described in this book, but a sample of programs can give you ideas to apply in creating a group that is suitable for your personal style, your clients, and the setting in which you work. Most of the group proposals described have the following components: organizing the group, group goals, group format, and group outcomes. After you have read the various group proposals, look for common denominators among these groups that may help you structure your own groups.

Regardless of the kind of group you design, you will be concerned with factors such as securing informed consent, creating trust, dealing with possible hidden agendas, and facilitating members through the various stages of a group, to mention a few. You are also responsible for documenting the process and outcomes of your groups. The kind of group you are leading, the setting in which you work, and your client population will influence your decisions about the kind of notes you may need to keep.

Group practitioners in school settings and in various community agency settings developed the proposals presented in Part 3. These practitioners followed their interests and the clients' needs of their work setting. These sample proposals provide practical examples of how group counselors are applying many of the concepts discussed in the previous chapters to their own groups. We encourage you to investigate ways to implement a group that interests you while meeting the needs that arise with the client population you serve.

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10 CHAPTER

Groups in School Settings

Introduction
Group Counseling in the School Setting
Guidelines for Group Work With Children and Adolescents
Play Therapy in Group Work With Children and Adolescents
Developmental Themes of Adolescence
Issues and Challenges in Leading Adolescent Groups
Helping Adolescents Deal With Anger and Conflict
Groups in College Counseling Centers
Points to Remember
Exercises



CHAPTER LEARNING OBJECTIVES

1. Describe the types of groups and other considerations that affect conducting groups in school settings (CACREP, 2016, Standard F)
2. Describe approaches to group formation, including recruiting, screening, and selecting members (CACREP, 2016, Standard E)
3. Identify guidelines for group work with children and adolescents
4. Identify therapeutic factors associated with play therapy in groups with children and adolescents
5. Describe key developmental themes of adolescence
6. Discuss challenges in leading adolescent groups
7. List guidelines in helping adolescents deal with anger and conflict
8. Describe topics used to structure groups in college counseling centers

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LO1

Introduction

In this chapter we describe groups for children and adolescents that are appropriate for school settings. The general group format described here can be applied in various other settings, including college and university counseling centers, private practice, and public and private clinics. Many of the ideas in this chapter also are useful for designing groups dealing with a variety of special needs of children, adolescents, and college students. This chapter alone will not provide you with enough information to conduct your own groups in a school setting. You will need to acquire and practice group facilitation skills and apply your knowledge of group process to any group you are planning. We encourage you to do further reading, attend specialized workshops, look for ways to cofacilitate groups with more experienced practitioners, and arrange for supervised field experience in facilitating groups.

Although the groups described here are in school settings, similar groups often are offered in community mental health agencies and in other settings. The roles and functions of school counselors differ from those of community mental health counselors, and the groups often have a different focus. Laws, regulations, policies, and the mission of the school or agency also may differ. Group practitioners need to be knowledgeable of these differences. There are no clear lines of demarcation for the many groups that are available in both school and community settings.

LO2

Group Counseling in the School Setting

Counseling groups in school settings cover a wide array of topics and formats. The group counseling services provided for children and adolescents in schools occupy a major place because of their efficacy in delivering information and treatment. Small groups have the potential to reach many students before they need remedial treatment for more serious mental health problems. School-based groups emphasize prevention and intervention strategies to support healthy student development and more effective ways of dealing with the tasks of daily living (Sink, Edwards, & Eppler, 2012). School-based counseling research confirms that small groups are of value for both the student participants and the school counselors; these programs influence the personal and social functioning of students and have been shown to improve academic performance (Sink et al., 2012; Steen, Bauman, & Smith, 2007). Groups play a key role in a comprehensive developmental school counseling program for children and adolescents because of their efficacy in delivering information and treatment (Steen, Henfield, & Booker, 2014).

Many school counseling groups focus on enhancing personal and social development and, at the same time, have a psychoeducational purpose (such as teaching study skills). Steen and colleagues (2014) describe a group counseling model designed to help K–12 school counselors integrate students' academic and personal-social development into their group work. Villalba (2007) examined the use of psychoeducational groups to address the social and academic

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concerns of children in K–12 school settings. Group work with children and adolescents was effective in decreasing bullying behaviors, increasing self-esteem for children of alcoholics, decreasing trauma-related anxiety in young survivors of natural disasters, and decreasing levels of anxiety and increasing academic performance for children from divorced parents. Villalba believes that wellness, like prevention, is an ideal conceptual approach for small and large group work in school settings.

DeLucia-Waack, Segrist, and Horne's (2007) DVD illustrates the value of a structured psychoeducational group for high school students. The leaders show flexibility and encourage members to interact with each other, and the structured exercises facilitate interaction. The value of preparation in forming a group, ways of developing group ground rules, icebreaker activities, how to encourage members to make connections, and how to assist members in identifying what they learned are also illustrated. The purpose of a psychoeducational group is different from the purpose of a therapy group, yet a similar process unfolds in both types of groups.

Groups in the schools are generally brief, structured, problem focused, homogeneous in membership, and may have a cognitive behavioral orientation. Both counseling and psychoeducational groups that focus on wellness and prevention are well suited for school settings. Teaching basic skills to all students in classroom guidance lessons and providing further services in small groups to children and adolescents who are at risk helps young people develop coping and communication skills. Treatment of more severe problems is generally not within the scope of counseling services offered in a school setting, although developmental groups with remedial aims may be offered. Because not all children or adolescents are ready for group participation, it is important to know how to suggest alternative helping approaches. School counselors need to make it a practice to know about referral resources and be willing to make use of these resources when it is in the child's or adolescent's best interest.

Typically, school counselors have an unrealistically large caseload. Regardless of how talented the counselor might be, there are limitations on what can be done to bring about significant behavior change. The counselor's time is often spent reacting to the immediate needs of children rather than on developing prevention programs. Given adequate resources and increased numbers of competent counselors, we would like to see school guidance programs include group counseling on the elementary, middle, and secondary levels. Group counseling aimed at cultivating caring and compassionate individuals can be an ideal forum for creating what Adlerians term "social interest." In the context of a group, priority could be given to helping children and adolescents deal with feelings of rejection, anger, alienation, and isolation. The group is also a place where young people can learn the meaning of belonging and contributing to society.

For a more detailed discussion of group counseling in the school setting, see Falco and Bauman (2014), Sink, Edwards, and Eppler (2012), Sklare (2005), Steen (2009), Steen, Bauman, and Smith (2007, 2008), Steen and Bemak (2008), Steen, Griffin, and Shi (2011), Steen, Henfield, and Booker (2014), Murphy (2015), and Winslade and Monk (2007).

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LO3

Guidelines for Group Work With Children and Adolescents

This section contains practical guidelines for school counselors who are considering setting up groups for both children and adolescents.

Developing a Sound Proposal

Designing group proposals is discussed in detail in Chapter 5, and the same principles apply here to planning groups for children and adolescents in school settings. As you develop your group proposal, keep these steps in mind:

- Describe your goals and purposes clearly.
- Develop a clearly stated rationale for your proposed group, including the reason a group approach has merit.
- Provide evidence to school administrators demonstrating that group counseling is an integral part of the school counseling program and that it is effective in changing student behavior and enhancing the educational experience (Sink et al., 2012).
- Clearly articulate to administrators, teachers, and parents the benefits children or adolescents derive from participating in a therapeutic group experience and identify how this group complements the mission of the school and will help students achieve not only academically but personally and socially as well (DeLucia-Waack, 2006c; Steen, Bauman, & Smith, 2007).
- State your aims, the procedures to be used, the questions for processing, the evaluation/assessment process, and the form of documentation you will use.
- Develop an attendance policy.
- Provide an orientation to the group for the parents of the children.

Legal Considerations

Be aware of your state's laws regarding group work with minors. Know the policies and procedures of the school district or agency where you work as they apply to your school, as well as the ethical principles specific to counseling children and adolescents. Do not tell children that you can keep everything they discuss confidential because you may be required to disclose information about them to your agency or school administrator. Be clear about what you can and cannot promise in the way of privacy. Be aware of your legal responsibility to report abuse or suspected abuse of minors. When a minor discloses information that creates even a suspicion of abuse or neglect, a school counselor has a duty to report this matter to Child Protective Services. In this situation confidentiality *must* be broken; the law requires you to take action by notifying the appropriate authorities. Bertram (2011) provides a concise overview of ethical and legal issues in group counseling, including the standard of care, member screening, informed consent, confidentiality and privilege, situations requiring breach of confidentiality, and danger to self or others. For other ethical considerations in setting up groups for minors, review the discussion of such standards in Chapters 3 and 5.

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Practical Considerations

The size and duration of a group depend on the age of the members. As a general rule, younger children should be in smaller groups with shorter sessions. Take into account the fact that the attention span of children ages 4 to 6 is quite different from that of children who are 10 or 12. Another consideration in forming a group is the severity of the children's problems. For example, a group of acting-out 12-year-olds might have to be as small as a group of preschoolers. It might also be important to find out whether a child in your group is currently taking any medications or experiencing other health issues. A child who has been diagnosed with ADHD might be taking medications that have behavioral side effects. This could provide a context for understanding some of the behaviors and symptoms you observe in the group. You must also consider your own tolerance for dealing with children who may be challenging for you. As is the case with adult clients, children can evoke your own countertransference. If you are aware of this, there is less chance that your feelings and reactions will interfere with your ability to work with children.

The Setting Consider the meeting place in terms of its effectiveness for the work you want to do with your young clients. Will they be able to roam around freely and not have to be continually asked to talk softly so as not to disturb others in an adjacent room? Will the site for group meetings provide privacy and freedom from interruptions? Is there anything in the room that could easily be damaged by the children or that is obviously unsafe for them? Will the furniture in the room comfortably accommodate active children?

Communicate Your Expectations Be able to tell the children or adolescents in their language about the purpose of your group, what you expect of them, and what they can expect from you. Make sure that they understand the basic, nonnegotiable ground rules, and attempt to involve them in establishing and reinforcing the rules that will govern their group.

Children and adolescents often test their limits as a way to ensure that you will keep them safe. This testing is typically a phase and will likely decrease as safety is established in the group. However, it can be expected to arise from time to time. Be intentionally patient within each session to avoid becoming more of a disciplinarian than a counselor.

Preparation Prepare adequately for each session, yet be flexible enough to adjust your format and topics for a given session to respond to spontaneous situations. Avoid insisting on "covering your agenda" no matter what; be creative, but not careless. Remember the broad goals of your group and use incidents in the group as teachable moments to help the members work on new skills. Be open to processing the interactions occurring within the group in the here and now as the power of peers' influence is very effective.

Involve Parents For some groups written parental permission may not be a legal requirement, but we think it is a good policy to secure the written consent of

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parents or guardians of any person under 18 who wishes to participate in group counseling as a school-related program. Doing so also tends to enhance the working relationship and gain the cooperation of legal guardians. Include some questions on the consent form to help you assess their perspective regarding how their child is currently functioning. Even if you have a meeting with the parents or guardians, ask them to sign a form; this reinforces their commitment to cooperate with their child's treatment. You can include group policy, meeting times and dates, and confidentiality policies on this form. As well, you can solicit suggestions on ways to contact them to follow up on the progress of the group or other important information.

Parents (or legal guardians) and counselors are partners with a common goal, which is helping the child or adolescent. As with the young people, explain to their parents your expectations and purposes in such a way that they can understand and not become suspicious. Approach them with an attitude of "How can you help me in my work with your child or adolescent, and how can we work as a team for a common purpose?" Doing so reduces the chances of encountering defensiveness on the part of parents. Spend an evening presenting your program in a group meeting of parents, or send them a letter briefly describing your groups. Providing parents with an outline of the goals of the groups and the topics, even sample activities, helps them to understand what is happening in the group without asking the group leader to break confidentiality. If you have the staff resources, organize a parent group at the same time that their children are participating in their own counseling group. As their children develop new or additional skills, the parents and families are able to benefit from similar opportunities.

Steen, Bauman, and Smith (2007) suggest that school counselors give presentations to parents, teachers, and administrators about the therapeutic factors involved in small group work as a way to increase their understanding of how groups work and the value of small groups in the overall mission of the academic program. Getting input from parents and teachers about their concerns can be an important step in gaining needed support for doing groups in the school.

Strategies in the Group

Self-Disclosure Consider the purposes and goals of your group in deciding how much to encourage self-disclosure, especially in matters relating to family life or personal trauma. Some personal topics may be beyond the scope of the group's purpose and more appropriate for individual therapy. Use judgment as to the appropriateness of letting a child go into detail about personal matters in a group. Anticipate some personal material they may disclose and how you might address this. For example, in a group in an elementary school, you may not want to let a child go into detail about an apparent physical abuse situation. If this occurs, encourage the child to express how he or she was affected by the incident. After the session ends, follow the procedures outlined by your school or agency to report suspected child abuse.

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Emphasize Confidentiality It is more difficult to maintain confidentiality in a school setting than in private practice. In school settings children and adolescents spend much time together outside of the group, where confidentiality leaks are more possible. As with adults, it is helpful to teach students how to talk about the group experience in a way that does not betray confidentiality. Help students understand that the information they share within a group belongs to them but that the information they hear or learn in a group belongs to the group. The counselor needs to communicate the importance of confidentiality by using language that is developmentally tailored for the age level. It is helpful to teach and to practice with the children how to talk about the group in appropriate ways and to give specific guidelines on what to say if someone probes them for information. Parental and teacher support can be solicited by encouraging parents to ask questions about their child's participation in the group. Remind parents, families, and teachers to avoid probing for specifics about other children, which could result in their child breaching confidentiality.

Special attention should be paid to orienting children to their responsibilities to one another. In group work with adults it is relatively simple to have a discussion about honoring the personal nature of the material that other group members reveal. Both adults and adolescents can clearly understand the ramifications associated with failing to honor the confidentiality of their peers. However, children need this clearly explained, and this matter deserves discussion in the group. A leader working with children might ask, "How would you feel if you found out a group member had told someone in class or on the playground something you said or did?" or "What if someone in this group shared with the teacher something another student said or did in this group?" Children need to know that the group counselor may talk with parents and teachers, and they have a right to know what kind of information will and will not be shared with adults. Children are more thoughtful than they are typically given credit for and are capable of understanding feelings and being sensitive to others.

Maintain Neutrality Avoid siding with children or adolescents against their parents or a particular institution. Young people may like and admire you for your patience and understanding and complain about missing these traits in parents or teachers. It is enough to acknowledge that their experience with you as their group leader is different from other adults.

Use Appropriate Exercises and Techniques During the beginning stage of the group it is appropriate to use interactive exercises that do not require deeply personal self-disclosure. As children and adolescents become more acquainted with the group process, the activities or exercises can become more challenging. Explain the purpose of the activity in a general way without diminishing its impact. Young people should not be pressured into participating in certain activities if they are uncomfortable doing so. Although their unwillingness to take part in exercises often stems from a lack of understanding, children or adolescents will sometimes be reluctant to participate because they may wonder about the purpose of such exercises or they may worry about being embarrassed and appearing silly.

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Through patience and by observing others in the group it is possible that reluctant members will eventually decide to participate more fully.

An excellent resource with appropriate exercises and activities for group work with children and adolescents is Foss, Green, Wolfe-Stiltner, and DeLucia-Waack (2008). For group activities for various types of multicultural groups and diversity-related groups, see Salazar (2009). Bauman and Steen's (2009) six-session DVD for a counseling group with a diverse group of fifth-grade students helps students achieve increased self-understanding and appreciate cultural diversity, demonstrates choosing activities appropriate for the developmental level of children, and shows how to process exercises in a group. Bauman and Steen (2012) also have a DVD for a diverse group with eighth-grade students titled *Celebrating Diversity: Leading Multicultural Groups for Middle School Students*.

Listen and Remain Open A skillful group counselor will listen to behavior as well as words. Leaders can provide children and adolescents with some reflective communication to help group members find words for their experiences. The use of creative arts activities—especially music, dance, movement, art, drama, play, and humor—are valuable ways to facilitate communication in groups (Gladding, 2016; Veach & Gladding, 2007).

Let children and adolescents lead the way, and follow their clues. Encourage young people to express themselves in their own words. Listen to their words, but pay attention to the possible meanings of their behavior as well. For example, if a child is acting out, is she telling you "Please stop me, because I can't stop myself"? If a child is continually calling out, he might be saying "Notice me! Nobody else does." Remaining open to what children are trying to tell us about themselves is essential if we are going to help them. Be aware of preconceived labels and diagnoses that may subtly influence your interactions. The children you work with are often categorized and labeled. Be careful not to limit the ability of children to change by responding to them as if they are their labels. You may be one of only a few people with the training to advocate on their behalf. Continue to explore other factors that may be hindering them from reaching their fullest potential.

Prepare for Termination Children and adolescents are quick to form attachments with adults who display a concerned and caring attitude toward them. Well before your group ends—for example, three sessions before the end of a 12-session group and as soon as possible for shorter groups—you should let those who participate in a group know that the termination point is not far off. This notice enables the children to express their reactions, and it enables you to share your reactions with them. Avoid promising them that you will keep in contact with them, if that is not possible. If you do not deal with these issues, they may see you as running out on them and consider you as one more adult they cannot trust. Help children identify support networks outside of the group throughout the duration of the group. To provide children or adolescents with a sense of closure, choose activities that help them identify what they have learned from the group and how they have been affected by others (DeLucia-Waack, 2006a, 2006b).

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Children and adolescents who will not be continuing with another cycle of group counseling could benefit from experiencing some kind of graduation. For example, a certificate of completion can provide group members with a sense of accomplishment. Offer students the opportunity to meet together again if new information, struggles, or successes arise. These meetings are often referred to as reunions, and it is reassuring for students to know that such reunions are possible. Take a moment to review the guidelines for the final stage of a group described in Chapter 9 for more information on termination.

Personal and Professional Qualifications

You need to recognize the impact that conducting a group with children or adolescents can have on you personally. For example, in working with youngsters who are abused and neglected, you might find it difficult to separate yourself from their life situations. If you are consistently preoccupied with their problems, you may discover that this is affecting your life and your relationships negatively. It is a personal matter for you to discover how much you are capable of giving, as well as how much and what you need to do to replenish yourself to stay excited and creative in your work.

Some of the *personal characteristics* that are important when working with children are patience, caring, authenticity, playfulness, a good sense of humor, the ability to tune in to and remember one's own childhood and adolescent experiences, firmness without punitiveness, flexibility, the ability to express anger without sarcasm, great concern for and interest in children, optimism that children can be active participants in their healing processes, and the other characteristics of group leaders that were described in Chapter 2.

We believe the following *professional qualifications* are especially important for those leading groups with children or adolescents:

- A thorough understanding of the developmental tasks and stages of the particular age group
- A good understanding of group process as it applies to working with children and adolescents
- Awareness, knowledge, and skills necessary to work effectively with children and adolescents from culturally diverse populations
- Supervised training in working with children and adolescents in groups before leading a group alone
- Knowledge of the literature and significant research pertaining to counseling children and adolescents within a group setting
- A clear understanding of the expectations of the school or agency where the groups are conducted

It is easy to overextend yourself when working with children and adolescents whose problems are pressing and severe. Be realistic and realize that you cannot work effectively with every student or provide all the needed services. Becoming knowledgeable about resources in your community can enable you to assist clients in finding services that meet their needs. Know the boundaries of your competence and the scope of your job description. Know how to differentiate between therapy groups and groups with a developmental, preventive, or educational

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focus. Groups in school settings typically focus on preventive and developmental issues, and they are linked to educational goals.

Getting Support for School Counseling Groups

The support of administrators and teachers in schools and agencies is especially important in setting up groups (Sink et al., 2012; Steen et al., 2007). If your design for a group is well organized, you will probably receive support and constructive suggestions from them. Remember that the school principal—not you—will probably be the target of criticism if your counseling group is ineffectively run or compromises the integrity of the school. If you have overlooked the need to get parental permission (where required), it is the principal who will field the calls from upset family members. The proposals described in this chapter have been carefully considered and have met with success; many of these ideas can be applied in designing your own groups.

One practitioner reported that she had encountered resistance from her school principal when she suggested forming a "divorce group" for children. She then renamed it the "loss group," which she thought would be more descriptive, and as a result gained support for the group. However, this new title confused the children. They reported to the office saying, "We're the *lost* group; we're here to be found." A group name should accurately describe the purpose of the group but not raise confusion or concerns for participants, parents, or the principal.

If you are interested in learning more about group counseling with children in the school setting, we recommend Ashby, Kottman, and DeGraaf (2008); DeLucia-Waack, Bridbord, Kleiner, and Nitza (2006); Falco and Bauman (2014); Foss, Green, Wolfe-Stiltner, and DeLucia-Waack (2008); Halstead, Pehrsson, and Mullen (2011); Murphy (2015); Salazar (2009); and Sink, Edwards, and Eppler (2012).

LO4

Play Therapy in Group Work With Children and Adolescents

Play therapy is increasing in popularity in groups for children and adolescents. The University of North Texas and some others offer a degree program in play therapy, and many books are now available on this subject. Play therapy has a long history in the treatment of children. Garry Landreth (2002), the founder and former director of the Center for Play Therapy at the University of North Texas, built on the philosophy of client-centered therapy in developing his child-centered approach to play therapy. Landreth views play therapy as an interpersonal relationship between child and therapist. The therapist provides selected play materials and creates a safe place in which the child can express and explore his or her feelings, thoughts, experiences, and behaviors through

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play. Play is the natural language that children most readily speak. Play therapy allows for self-expression in a less threatening way than direct verbal communication. Play supports the development of cognitive skills, language skills, coping skills, and other developmental tasks in childhood. Group play therapy in schools can focus on exploring interpersonal issues that help or hinder academic progress. Connecting the interventions of play therapy with academic success helps to justify this approach in school settings. Group play therapy can be instrumental in helping children feel safe, in creating positive school relationships, and in providing a space for learning with few internal distractions (Sweeney, Baggerly, & Ray, 2014).

Regardless of the type of group you are leading, play-based activities can help children process the material generated in the group. Play therapy is most commonly used for children under the age of 12, but it is sometimes practiced with adolescents as well. Children respond very warmly to these activities because of their developmental appropriateness. Playing provides some psychological distance from material that might be too difficult or painful for a child to talk about. Children often leave a play therapy experience in a happy state, and they look forward to coming with great enthusiasm. In group play therapy, children tend to feel like they are coming in to play for an hour with friends.

Any existing group format can be altered to integrate some play therapy elements. There are many different theoretical orientations to play therapy, including Adlerian play therapy, psychoanalytic play therapy, child-centered play therapy, cognitive behavioral play therapy, ecosystemic play therapy, Gestalt play therapy, Jungian play therapy, and thematic play therapy, (Sweeney et al., 2014). The Adlerian approach lends itself especially well to group work with children (see Kottman & Meany-Walen, 2016). Sandtray therapy, which can be applied as a way of exploring developmentally appropriate treatment options for preadolescents with behavioral difficulties, has been proved to be effective with preadolescents (Flahive & Ray, 2007). Concept and methods from the various theoretical orientations can be incorporated into a variety of groups for children, as you will see in the group proposals detailed later in this chapter.

If you expect to employ group play therapy with children or adolescents, it is important to obtain formal training and supervised clinical experience from a play therapy practitioner. Many graduate programs are now offering courses in play therapy, and organizations such as the Association for Play Therapy and its chapters offer training all over the country. The Association for Play Therapy (2008) provides guidelines for registered play therapists and supervisors. Conferences, training, networking, research, and other resources are available through this organization. For more information on play therapy, see *Play Therapy: Basics and Beyond* (Kottman, 2011), *Partners in Play: An Adlerian Approach to Play Therapy* (Kottman & Meany-Walen, 2016), *Group Play Therapy: A Dynamic Approach* (Sweeney, Baggerly, & Ray, 2014), and *The Handbook of Jungian Play Therapy With Children and Adolescents* (Green, 2014).

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A School Counseling Group for 6- to 11-Year-Olds

This section is written from the perspective of Marianne Schneider Corey.

I designed a group for children ranging in age from 6 to 11 at an elementary school. My caseload included 10 to 15 children, and I was to see each child once a week for about an hour for a total of 24 visits. The principal, the teacher, or the school nurse referred the children to me; almost without exception, these children were identified as having learning problems. Often these learning disabilities were a reflection of their emotional conflicts. It was up to me to design a group that would improve the children's behavior in school.

Organizing the Group

Contact With School Personnel

Being aware that outsiders are sometimes mistrusted in schools, my first goal was to earn the trust of the teachers and administrators. I met with them to determine what they hoped the project would accomplish. I told them that I wanted to work closely with them, providing feedback about the children, making specific recommendations, and getting their suggestions. I let them know that I intended to work with the children individually and in groups and to involve the parents in the treatment process as much as possible.

Accordingly, I developed a program in which I was in continuous contact with the children's teachers, principal, and parents. The teachers and the principal were very cooperative about meeting with me. I also spoke frequently with the school psychologist and the school secretaries about particular children, gathering as much information as I could. This information turned out to be most helpful.

The Setting

The setting for my work with the children was not ideal. The school was short on space (a new school was being built), and I was continually looking for a place to meet with the children.

When the weather allowed, we often met on the school lawn. I needed a place where the children could explore, touch, talk loudly, shout if they were angry, or give vent to any other emotions they were experiencing. If I took them off campus or did anything special with them, I first obtained written permission from the parents and the school authorities. Although I never had an ideal place to work, this did not keep me from working effectively with the children, as we often improvised together. The children were very adaptive, and I too had to learn to adapt to less than ideal situations.

Due to the setting, I had to pick up the children from their classrooms, which concerned me. How would the children react to being singled out? Would my special attention to them amid their peers affect them negatively? Fortunately, I found the contrary to be true. The children responded very positively to my coming to pick them up and were always ready to come with me, even during recess time.

Initial Contact With the Parents

After meeting with the school staff, who identified which children I would be working with, I contacted the parents of each child and attempted to arrange for an individual meeting with the parents. They knew before I visited them about my intended involvement with their child because I had asked the principal and the child's teacher to contact them. During my initial contact, I explained that the teacher had become concerned about the student's behavior in class and had referred the child to me. This interview gave the parents a chance to get to know me and to ask questions, and it gave me the chance to get the parents' permission to work with their child. At this time I gathered information regarding any difficulties the parents were having with the child and collected the data I needed to complete numerous forms. If parents became anxious over my probing or over the fact that *their* child had been singled out for counseling, I explained to them that because teachers have to deal with so many children they cannot always provide all the attention a child needs. It would be my job, I said, to provide this extra attention.

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Although the school's policy stipulated obtaining parental permission for children to become participants in a group, this is not a required policy in all school districts. State laws regarding parental permission to counsel minors also vary. As a general rule, I think it is best to get the parents' permission and to work with them as allies rather than risk their disapproval by counseling their children without their knowledge and consent. There are exceptions, however. When counselors are not legally required to secure the consent of parents and when notifying them could be detrimental to the minor client, the welfare of these children always takes priority.

For the most part parents were willing to cooperate and gave their consent. In response to my question about any difficulties they might be experiencing with their child at home, which I asked to get clues to the child's behavior in school, the parents were guarded at first. They became much more open with time and frequent contacts. My aim was not to communicate in any way that they were "bad" parents, as this would certainly have aroused their defensiveness. Their children were experiencing difficulties, and I wanted to solicit their help in assisting the students to work through these problems. By going into the child's home, I was able to get information relating to the problems the child was exhibiting that would otherwise have been difficult, if not impossible, to obtain.

I told the parents that their children would be discussing with me problems related to school, home, and peers. I explained that I wished to keep as confidential as possible what the child and I would be exploring in our sessions. Therefore, I explained, I would let them know in a general way how I was proceeding with the child but would not reveal any of the specifics, unless I was required to do so by law.

I also told them that I hoped to see them sometimes together with their children. It was difficult to see some parents again after my initial contact, however, because every one of them was employed. I was able to make at least some additional contact with most parents, and I spoke with others on the telephone.

Special Problems Requiring Out-of-Group Attention

Like the parents, the teachers provided me with ongoing information regarding the children's progress. I was able to use this information in deciding how long to see a particular child or what problem area to focus on. In addition, the teachers prepared written evaluations for the program director, and they shared these evaluations with me. I kept documentation of my work with each child in the group, my observation of the child, my recommendations for teachers, and as well, I kept notes regarding my contacts with teachers and parents.

In doing these groups I learned that children have a multitude of developmental issues with which they must cope. There are many avenues of help for these problems. In working effectively with children, counselors do well to involve as many resources and people as possible. There is room for creativity in developing groups to meet the diverse needs and the diverse cultural backgrounds of children. It is important to let the parents or legal guardians know about these programs and resources so that they, too, are involved in the helping process.

Because I was unable to provide the necessary tutorial assistance, I contacted a nearby university and recruited five graduate students to tutor the children for credit in their child psychology course. In addition to providing tutorial services, they gave the children additional positive individual attention. This tutoring proved very successful for both the children and the university students.

When I detected health problems, I referred the child to the school nurse. When I suspected neglect or abuse, I took the appropriate action. As counselors who work with minors, we need to be aware of the reporting laws for suspected abuse in our state as well as our work setting. We must know the specific steps to be taken in making the required reports. In a school setting the first step may be to report a situation to the principal. It is always helpful to communicate with Child Protective Services (or the Department of Social Services) to obtain information on assessing and reporting suspected child abuse.

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Many children are undernourished, inappropriately clothed, and in need of medical assistance, recreational opportunities, or supervision after school. Counseling is more likely to have an effect if the child's basic needs are being met. I found it necessary to do much of the legwork required to obtain food, clothing, money, or special services for the children and their families. Essentially, I had a lot of case management responsibilities. Some families resisted turning to outside agencies because of pride or fear that strings would be attached or simply out of ignorance about where to go for help. When a family did want help with emotional, economic, or medical problems, I referred them to one of the appropriate agencies, but I often also made the contacts with the agencies and did the paperwork they required. More often than not counselors do not have time to make the contacts I have described, but they can be creative in finding ways to delegate these tasks to others.

Group Format

Initial Contact With the Children

The children were reluctant to initiate a conversation, being accustomed only to answering questions. They needed some structure and some guidelines for expressing themselves and an acknowledgment that it was difficult for them. I introduced myself to them, saying that I was a special type of teacher called a counselor. I explained that their teacher was concerned about their behavior in class and that they would be talking with me several times a week—individually, as a group, and in their homes. I told them that we would be discussing problems they had in school, at home, or with fellow students.

Because of my belief that children's rights to privacy are often ignored and violated, I let them know that I would be talking about them with their parents and teachers. I explained that I would tell them when I made such contacts. Although I said I did consider much of what we would talk about in the group to be confidential, I told them I would discuss with their parents and teachers anything that would be important in helping them work through any of their difficulties. At this time I also let them know that they were not to talk to others about what fellow group members revealed. This was one of the rules we discussed again in the group sessions. I told them that they could talk about matters that concerned them, including their fears and their hurts. Additionally, I let them know that I could not keep everything confidential, especially if it concerned their safety. In language that they could understand, I explained the purpose of confidentiality and its limitations. They were also informed that they would not be allowed to hurt other children, either physically or verbally, or to destroy any property. Other rules were established, and I made the children aware of their responsibility. To be part of the group, they had to agree to follow these rules.

Working With the Children in a Group

My goal was to pinpoint some of the children's maladaptive behaviors, teach them how to express emotions without hurting themselves or others, and provide a climate in which they would feel free to express a range of feelings. I wanted to convey to the youngsters that feelings such as anger did not get them into trouble; rather, it is certain ways of acting on these feelings that can lead to problems. In an effort to teach them ways of safely expressing the full gambit of their feelings, I involved them in a variety of activities, including role playing, play therapy, acting out special situations, painting, finishing stories that I began, putting on puppet shows, playing music, movement, and dancing.

The groups that were easiest to work with and most productive were composed of 3 to 5 children of the same age and gender. In larger groups I found myself (1) unable to relate intensely to individuals, (2) slipping into the role of disciplinarian to counteract the increased distractions, (3) feeling frustrated at the number of children competing for my attention, and (4) not having enough time left over to pay attention to the underlying dynamics. In addition, children between the ages of 6 and 11 tend to become impatient if they have to wait very long for their turn to speak.

I took care to combine withdrawn children with more outgoing ones, but I also felt that it was important for the

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children to be with others who were experiencing similar conflicts. For example, I put in the same group two boys who felt much anger, hurt, grief, and frustration over their parents' divorces and subsequent remarriages. They slowly learned how to express their feelings about not having much contact with the parent they didn't live with. At first the boys could only express their feelings symbolically, through play; later they learned to put words to their emotions and to talk about their feelings.

As I had planned, I provided some time for each child during which he or she could have my attention alone. I noticed that in the group all the children became less jealous of one another about me and trusted me more once I had begun to provide this individual time.

Alone, the children were more cooperative and less competitive. They felt less need to seek attention in undesirable ways. Having an adult spend time with them individually gave them a sense of importance. With the teacher's consent I frequently visited the children who were in my group in their classrooms and on the playground, sometimes just observing and sometimes making a brief contact through touch or words. Although this was time consuming, it proved to be productive in the long run.

Our scheduled group and individual sessions took place twice a week and lasted from half an hour to an hour. It would have been a mistake for me to insist that sessions always last a certain length of time because the children's patience varied from session to session.

When they wanted to leave a group session, I would say in a friendly manner that they were free to leave, but I wished they would stay until the session was over. They usually elected to stay. If they chose to leave, I would not have them come back to that session. Most of the time the children enjoyed the sessions. It was a good practice to let them know in advance that a session was coming to an end and then to be firm about having them leave and not give in to their demands that the group continue.

My groups were open, in that new members could join. The children already in the group handled this situation very well. They knew the newcomer from school and did not meet the child with any negative reactions. During the sessions, I let the children lead the way and listened to what they had to say, directly or through various symbolic means. Playing with puppets turned out to be an excellent means of revealing a variety of emotions and dramatizing situations that produce conflict. I made puppets available to the first- and second-grade children but found that even the fourth- and fifth-grade students were able to use them to vent their pent-up emotions.

The groups offered the children the opportunity to act out situations that aroused conflicting feelings. Sometimes I would suggest a problem situation, and at other times the children would select a problem to act out. The children would take the role of teacher, friend, principal, parent, brother, sister, or whoever else was involved. In this way they were able to release their emotions without hurting others.

Several sessions might pass before a child would speak freely. I sat on the floor close to the children during the sessions, often maintaining physical contact, which seemed to have a calming effect by itself. I listened to them attentively and often reflected for them what they were saying. More important, however, I communicated to them, usually nonverbally, that I was with them, that what they were saying was important, and that I cared about what they had to say. I insisted that other members in the group listen, and I reassured all of them that each would have a time to speak. This is a very difficult concept to get across, especially to a 6- or 7-year-old who is still learning to share.

After a session that I thought had been unproductive, I was sometimes surprised to hear a teacher comment on a child's changed behavior. After one such session, a boy who had previously been very destructive and disobedient became cooperative and able to relate to his peers. Pounding a lump of clay, which could be interpreted as nonproductive, turned out to have been very important to him. It had relieved much of his anger and so reduced his need to strike out at others.

At times I questioned whether my work with the children was doing any good. Changes in their behavior were slow in coming and sometimes temporary.

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Some children gave the appearance of improving one week, yet the next week their behavior would again be very negative. My firm belief that a child can change if afforded the opportunity to change was challenged again and again. However, most children did make definite changes, as observed by the teacher, the principal, the parents, and me. Children who were truant began to come to school more regularly. A boy who was in the habit of stealing and giving his loot to other children so they would like him learned that his behavior was one of the reasons others disliked him in the first place, and he began to get their attention through more positive actions. A girl who had been conditioned not to trust learned to make friends and to reach out first, doing what at one time she had most feared.

These changes, though encouraging, needed to be reinforced at home. Although most parents welcomed many of their child's new behaviors, some found the new behavior threatening. For instance, one girl caused her mother some anxiety by beginning to ask probing questions about her absent father. I encouraged this mother—and other parents facing similar problems—to try to listen to the child nondefensively.

It was disconcerting to know that some of the children frequently faced difficult circumstances at home, and yet I realized that I did not have control over that domain. Rather than allowing myself to get too discouraged over the fact that I could not change their situation at home, I had to remind myself that I could provide them with a positive experience at school that would have a constructive impact on them. As counselors, we need to remind ourselves to focus on what we can do and not become overwhelmed by all that we cannot do.

Termination of the Group

When I began to work with the children, I told them that the sessions would go on for only a limited time during the school year. Several sessions before termination, I reminded them that the group and individual sessions would be ending soon, and we discussed the coming end of our meetings.

Although I had been affectionate with the children during our time together, I had not deceived them by becoming a substitute mother or by establishing myself as a permanent fixture who would totally satisfy all their needs. I was aware of establishing appropriate boundaries in carrying out the primary purpose of the group experience. By being realistic about the limits of my job from the beginning, I was able to prevent termination from being a negative experience for the children.

Teacher Evaluation of the Counseling Program

Like the parents, the teachers provided me with ongoing information regarding the children's progress. I was able to use this information in deciding how long to see a particular child or what problem area to focus on. In addition, the teachers completed written evaluations for the program director, and they shared these evaluations with me.

A Group for Elementary School Children of Divorce and Changing Families

This section is written from the perspective of Karen Kram Laudenslager, a school counselor. (For more information on these groups, contact Karen at Allentown School District, 31 S. Penn Street, Box 328, Allentown, PA 18105; telephone: 484-765-4055; email: Klaudenslager@aol.com.)

It is not uncommon for many children in any elementary school to come from divorced homes. These pupils face a number of personal and social problems, which include being lonely, feeling responsible for the divorce, experiencing divided loyalties, not knowing how to deal with parental conflicts, and facing the loss of family stability. Researchers have demonstrated the effectiveness of groups in addressing the psychological, social, and academic problems associated with children of divorce

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(DeLucia-Waack, 2011). Schools and community agencies are offering groups for children structured around these themes. This proposal describes counseling groups designed for children from divorced and changing families.

Organizing the Group

Before actually getting a group going, a great deal of careful preliminary work needs to be done. This preparation includes conducting a needs survey, announcing the group to children and teachers, obtaining parental permission, orienting the children to the rules for participating in a group, and presenting my goals in a clear way to the children, parents, teachers, and administrators. If adequate attention is not given to these preliminary details, the group may never materialize.

Survey the Children's Needs

It is helpful to assess the needs of children before deciding on a program. I do this by making an initial classroom visit to discuss with both the teachers and the children how small group counseling can be beneficial. I explain the topical focus of these groups or, as I later refer to them, "clubs." The family club is geared for grades 2 through 5. I explain that a specific day and time have been scheduled for club meetings at each grade level and that all clubs run for 30 minutes once a week for six sessions.

The needs survey is then handed out, and I ask all students to think about the issues and react truthfully. I explain that these surveys are private and will be read only by the classroom teacher and me. The selection of students is based on comments by both students and teachers. For a sample survey form, see DeLucia-Waack (2001).

Obtain Parental Permission

A letter is sent home with every child who has agreed to participate in the group. The letter outlines the issues and topics to be discussed, requests parental permission, and encourages parental support and involvement. I am convinced of the value of involving both parents whenever possible. I encourage each child to discuss the group with his or her parents. For a sample consent form, see DeLucia-Waack (2001).

Group Rules

All students voluntarily agree to be members of the club. I encourage children who are shy or slightly reluctant to give it a try. Anyone who wishes to leave the group is free to do so.

Children always have the right to remain silent. I reinforce the importance of listening and learning from one another. Some students feel more comfortable knowing that they will never be forced to share or discuss any issue that they feel is private. Other rules include (1) anyone who wants to may have a turn, (2) everyone is listened to, (3) no laughing or making fun of what anyone says, (4) honesty is required, and (5) confidentiality is respected.

The students, with my guidance, make up the rules during the first session. They usually come up with all of the rules mentioned earlier on their own. If the group does not identify some critical norms, I will add them to our list of rules. I explain the reasons for the rules, which increases the chances that the children will abide by them. Finally, we all sign our names, making a commitment and agreeing to follow the rules. These rules are posted and reviewed before each session.

Group Goals

What Children Need to Know

Through my research, reading, and direct contact with children, I have discovered some important messages children need to hear. I continually discuss, explain, and reinforce these statements throughout the six weekly sessions:

- You are special.
- You can get through this difficult time.
- You have people who care about you.
- It (the divorce or separation) is not your fault.
- You are not to blame.
- It is not your divorce, and no one is divorcing you. Your parents are divorcing each other.

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- You did not cause the problems between your parents, and you cannot fix them.
- You can help each other.

What I Hope to Accomplish

Some objectives of the groups are:

- Give support when needed
- Let children know they are not alone
- Teach coping skills
- Reinforce students' need to talk and deal with feelings
- Help children deal with emotional and behavioral concerns so they can concentrate on learning and work to reach their potential
- Offer resources to students and parents such as bibliotherapy and outside private counseling when needed
- Help children open lines of communication with other students, teachers, and parents

Counseling groups, support groups, and psychoeducational groups for children of divorce focus on coping with the reality of the divorce situation and the feelings associated with this reality. Falco and Bauman (2014) capture the essence of a support group for children of divorce when they state: "Group counseling can be a practical, efficient, and effective treatment because it provides a mechanism for students to talk aloud about feelings and experiences that may assist in reducing some of the negative emotions associated with divorce" (p. 321).

DeLucia-Waack (2001) has identified seven specific goals for children of divorce groups, all of which are goals for my group as well: (a) help children acquire an accurate picture of the divorce process through discussion and information, (b) normalize common feelings around divorce, (c) create a safe and supportive place for children to talk about their concerns related to the divorce situation, (d) identify, express, and understand feelings about the divorce, (e) acquire new coping skills to deal with feelings and situations experienced as a result of divorce; (f) help children test reality, and (g) make plans for the future.

Group Format

The focus of these clubs is developmental and preventive. The groups are designed to provide support, teach coping skills, and help children of changing families explore ways to express and deal with their feelings. When more involved counseling is needed, the parents are always contacted and an outside referral is made.

Any counselor who works in an elementary school can testify to the importance of getting feedback and support from teachers and parents. I have found that it is critical to involve parents, teachers, and administrators in these group programs so that they become allies of the children and the counselor. Their support of the program goes a long way toward ensuring its success; their resistance can thwart its progress.

Teachers' feedback is critical because they see the student daily and can monitor changes in behavior. I make an effort to talk with each classroom teacher as often as possible. Teachers can tell counselors about pupils' self-esteem, self-confidence, interaction with their peers, and homework completion. They can also share comments and reactions that students make in class, both orally and in their written work. All of this information helps me monitor the students' emotional and social progress.

Sessions of 30 minutes each, once a week for 6 weeks, work well. This schedule gives me time to run more groups and see more children. With so many students experiencing family changes, I try to help as many as possible. This time structure interferes only minimally with classroom learning. I try to be sensitive to the reactions of both students and teachers to interrupting the learning process. Too much time out of class for extended periods can cause additional stress, and we are all concerned with supporting and enhancing the learning process, not disrupting it.

The Initial Meeting

The first session is clearly structured by focusing on a discussion of the purpose of the club, on my role as a

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group facilitator, and on helping the children identify why they are in the group. We play a "name game" in which the children introduce themselves by selecting an adjective describing them that starts with the first letter of their first name (such as Wonderful Wanda or Nice Nick). The only guideline is that the adjective must be a positive one. We define *family*, and each child introduces him- or herself by answering the question "Who am I, and who lives at my house?" I ask younger children to draw pictures of who lives in different houses. We discuss how many different places we live and with whom. I encourage them to describe how it is for them to be in their family. At this session the ground rules are established and written on chart paper for use as a reminder at all subsequent sessions. My goal for this first meeting is to help the children find out that they are not alone in their situation. If time allows, I encourage them to see similarities and differences in their family situations. I may ask "Who would like to share how your family is the same as or different from others in this group?"

The Next Four Sessions

I have found that my groups differ somewhat depending on the themes brought out at the initial session. I use selected exercises as a focus for interaction. The middle four sessions are structured in accordance with the needs of those who are in the group. Here are a few of the activities that are often part of these sessions:

- We play the "feeling game." Students brainstorm feelings, and we write them down. The children then select three feelings that describe how they feel about their family situation, and we discuss them.
- The children identify three wishes they have for their family. One overwhelming wish that generally emerges is that their mother and father will get back together. They also wish to spend more time with the noncustodial parent. These children often express how difficult it is for them to be placed in the middle of a struggle, and they wish for peace. They would like this harmony at any cost, and they are willing to do anything to bring it about.
- We go around the table taking turns to "check in," sharing on a scale from 1 to 10 how we are feeling and why.
- The children decide "what I want each of my parents to know." (Stepparents and stepbrothers and stepsisters may also be included, if appropriate.) I often find that children are hesitant to reveal some differences they might have with their new stepmother or stepfather. They frequently want their parents to understand their feelings about being in a new family. Sometimes children feel forced to make an adjustment before they are ready, and they often have uncomfortable feelings that have not been discussed.
- We discuss what children can control and what they cannot. For example, they can control their own behavior. We also talk about ways they can control certain feelings. However, they cannot control the decisions that their parents make about the divorce or current living situations. I also talk with the children about the fact that this is not *their* divorce. In other words, Mom and Dad are divorcing each other, not the children. What I hope to get across to the group members is that they did not cause the divorce and cannot "fix" the situation. Much of the group time is devoted to exploring and brainstorming alternatives for the children to change themselves in their situations at home.
- We discuss how change comes about. The children identify what they consider to be positive and negative changes in their lives as a result of the new family situation.
- A question box is available during all sessions. Students can anonymously write questions or concerns that they might not feel comfortable sharing in group and drop them in the question box. These issues are discussed at the next session.

The Last Session

As is true of the initial session, the final meeting is also fairly structured, this time around involving the tasks of termination. The children typically discuss feelings about the club ending and identify what they have learned

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from these sessions. There is also some time for a special celebration with cupcake or popcorn treats. Each student receives a recognition certificate, which says: *The Counselor Said I Am Special!*

Group Outcomes

Student Perceptions

Students report feeling more comfortable with themselves and with their family situations when they belong to the club and realize that they are not alone. They need to identify with other children who are experiencing similar concerns and feelings. Together, group members can begin to understand the stages that everyone goes through and can learn skills to help themselves feel better. Through the group process, they help one another let go of what they cannot control and take responsibility for what they can control.

Parent Perceptions

Parents report that their children enjoy the club meetings and often come home and share what was discussed. Their children gain a better understanding of divorce by learning how others adjust. Parents are often in so much pain and conflict themselves during the separation or divorce that they are relieved and happy that someone else is there supporting their children.

Parents show an interest in what their children are doing in the group, and parents often read some of the recommended books with their children. Many parents have expressed a need for more information on how they can help their children. I have offered evening workshops and parenting classes. I would like to develop an ongoing parent support group to meet the needs of adults. I have also thought it might be helpful to facilitate one or two sessions with both parents and children together.

Follow-Up

My follow-up consists of checking with teachers on the students' progress and checking with the students themselves by classroom visits, by seeing them individually, and by encouraging self-referrals. I also hold club "reunions" the following year to see how things have been going.

Personal Sources of Frustration

The biggest frustration for me is ending the clubs. The children always resist terminating and bargain or plead to continue with more sessions. I find it extremely difficult to end when I know how much these children need to talk and learn. I am unable to directly solve some of the children's problems, and that adds to my level of frustration. Here are some of the complex problems these children face:

- Infrequent visitations with a parent as a result of the parent's emotional problems
- Dislocations because a child is "interfering" with a parent's relationships
- Frequent court testimony in sexual abuse cases
- Violence in the family
- Parental neglect
- Conflicts over being asked by parents to choose sides
- Parents' extramarital affairs
- Alcohol and drug abuse
- Spousal abuse
- Physical or emotional abuse
- Custody battles
- Financial concerns

Another source of frustration is time. There never seems to be enough time to see all the students who need help. Nor is there enough time to meet with all the parents to discuss the progress of each child. I do, however, refer families for outside counseling if during the club sessions I see a need for more in-depth therapy.

Concluding Comments

I have found the group experience to be very effective and instrumental in supporting students with changes and family issues. Students are able to connect with each other and offer support, encouragement, suggestions, and hope. In the group they can help each other to understand feelings and learn how to handle difficult

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situations in a safe place. It has been my experience that this small group structure is extremely beneficial. I strongly recommend that counselors provide this kind of counseling service for students.

For those interested in designing a children of divorce group, a useful resource is Janice DeLucia-Waack's (2001) book, *Using Music in Children of Divorce Groups: A Session-by-Session Manual for Counselors*. This manual shows how exercises and music can help children express emotions and apply what they learn in a group to their daily lives.

A Group for Children Who Have Been Abused

This section is written from the perspective of Teresa M. Christensen, PhD. (For further information, contact Teresa at Regis University, CPS, Department of Education and Counseling; telephone: 303-964-5727, ext. 5727; email: tchriste@regis.edu.)

Introduction

The effects of child abuse are pervasive and often multifaceted. Aside from the obvious physical injury sustained by any number of abusive violations, children who are abused often experience a range of feelings and thoughts related to anger and hostility, fear and anxiety, vulnerability and powerlessness, sadness and loss, shame, and guilt. The detrimental outcome of child abuse often presents itself in children who struggle with trust issues, self-blame, depression, isolation, poor self-image, and many other interpersonal relationship issues (Gil, 2006). The literature and research have called for an increase in literature that illuminates mental health services specific to children affected by abuse and trauma. Experts in the field have responded to such needs (Gil, 2010; Terr, 2009), but counselors continually yearn for new ideas about how to work with children affected by abuse. Many experts contend that effective interventions focus on the appropriate expression of emotions, a positive self-image, interpersonal relationship skills, and rebuilding trust in a variety of social situations (Gil, 2010). Therefore, interventions that explore interpersonal and social relationships can be highly effective with those who suffer from abuse. In particular, group counseling provides a nonjudgmental and safe climate in which children are encouraged to address a multitude of issues and in which they have the opportunity to establish relationships with their peers who have similar experiences. After several years of experience, I have found group counseling to be very helpful for children affected by abuse. The model that follows has emerged from my experiences as an individual, group, and family counselor with children affected by varying forms of abuse.

Group Goals

The main goal of this group is to foster a therapeutic relationship in which children who have been abused feel safe enough to risk trusting other children and another adult. The group is designed to establish a safe environment, empower children, and enhance their sense of self. This group is also structured to assist children in discovering that they are not alone in their experiences and feelings, thus providing an environment in which children have an opportunity to express difficult and complex emotions and act out the intrusive and abusive experiences. By assisting children to express the full range of mixed and confusing emotions felt toward the perpetrator, children experience a sense of control and mastery (Gil, 2010), which is another goal of this group. By the end of the group, it is hoped that all children will have learned to express their feelings appropriately and acknowledged their personal strengths, and will have developed the skills they need for healthy interpersonal interactions and relationships.

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Setting Up the Group

Screening

Screening is crucial when counseling children who have been abused, and timing is essential when determining when children are ready for group. Most of all, children must be ready and willing to interact with other children in a therapeutic setting as evidenced by their desire to play games, talk, and generally spend time with peers. All children in my groups have completed or are concurrently involved in individual and family counseling, and I utilize case notes and clinical impressions to assist in the screening process. When I believe children are ready, I invite them to participate in group counseling. I emphasize that they can decline, thus empowering them to make choices.

Group counseling is contraindicated if (a) the abuse happened recently, (b) the abuse is still highly traumatizing to the child, (c) the child has experienced serious psychological disturbances such as suicidal behavior, self-mutilation, severe mood swings, or thought disturbances (hallucinations or delusions), or (d) the child was abused by more than one person at a time. However, it is my belief that all children can benefit from group counseling when they are ready.

The functioning and climate of the group are dependent on the behavioral patterns of prospective members. Accordingly, it is essential to balance the group with members similar in age, physical size, and gender. Likewise, the type and severity of the abuse must be considered when composing the group so that children are not retraumatized by other children's stories. Once children are deemed appropriate for group counseling, consent from the legal guardian must be obtained.

Parent/Legal Guardian Consent

In most cases, I converse with parents/legal guardians in person, but sometimes I send a letter of consent. The letter outlines issues of confidentiality, therapeutic factors, topics to be discussed in the group, and a description of the process, which provides a rational for group counseling with children affected by abuse (see letter). I emphasize that group does not take the place of individual or family counseling, but that it is a supplement to the current treatment plan.

Written consent is obtained from legal guardians prior to informing the child about the group. (It is important to attain proof of legal guardianship, particularly when children don't reside with their biological parents.) Legal guardians may include foster or adoptive parents, grandparents, or other members of the extended family.

Group Composition and Characteristics

This type of group works most efficiently with children of similar ages (only 1 to 3 years apart) who have suffered the same type of abuse. Adolescents can also benefit from such a group, but the activities described here pertain to a group for children ages 7 to 12 who have been sexually abused. Because developmental and gender issues need to be considered, each group is structured a bit differently depending on the specific needs of the members. Due to factors such as trust, power and control, group cohesion, and boundary issues, this is a closed group. The group consists of five to seven members who meet for 45 to 60 minutes once a week for 10 consecutive sessions.

Setting

The ideal setting to facilitate groups with children ages 4 to 12 is a playroom or similarly structured space that is large enough to accommodate the number of members. This space should enable a variety of activities that incorporate both nondirective and directive play, including a variety of expressive arts activities. Necessary materials include therapeutic toys and games, art supplies, puppets, blowing bubbles, sand and miniatures, and other creative materials.

Group Format

I incorporate directive and nondirective techniques throughout the entire group process. Development and process issues are addressed by dividing each group session into three segments: warm-up, work, and wrap-up. All sessions begin with 5 to 10 minutes for warm-up,

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Dear Parent/Legal Guardian:

As you are well aware, the detrimental outcome of child abuse often presents itself in children who struggle with trust issues, self-blame, depression, anxiety, isolation, poor self-image, and many other interpersonal relationship issues. While such problems are currently or have been addressed with your children in individual and/or family counseling, I believe that group counseling is yet another opportunity that can be highly therapeutic and beneficial to your child's mental well-being.

Throughout my experience as a counselor and play therapist, I have found that many children affected by abuse struggle with relationships, namely peer relationships. Research has indicated and I firmly believe that group counseling can assist many children in (a) learning how to trust others, (b) understanding that they aren't alone in their experiences, (c) developing healthy interpersonal relationship skills, and (d) increasing their sense of control and mastery when in social situations. By interacting with others who have similar feelings, experiences, and concerns, children learn how to accept and cope with their emotions and thoughts more effectively.

Based on clinical observations and my professional judgment, I believe that your child is ready and prepared for a group counseling experience. Accordingly, I am requesting that you grant permission for _____(child's name) to take part in a 10-week group that will be made up of approximately five to seven other children who have similar concerns and are compatible in terms of age, size, and gender.

Group sessions will include an array of structured and non-structured conversations and activities related to abuse and other mental health issues. All children and parents will be informed about confidentiality, but I cannot control what children say or do outside of the session. However, I will make every effort to enforce confidentiality and ensure the physical and emotional safety of your child. Should you have any questions or concerns about the group, please contact me at _____.

By signing this form, you acknowledge and support your child's participation in this group counseling experience and hereby provide written consent.

_____	_____
Parent's/Guardian's Signature	Date
_____	_____
Witness's Signature	Date
_____	_____
Teresa M. Christensen, PhD	Date

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which includes (a) a check-in with each member about how he or she is feeling today, (b) time to reflect on and talk about what happened in the last session, and (c) discussion about what the group session will be like. The next 25 to 35 minutes is the work phase, which includes either a structured activity or free play. The final 10 to 15 minutes is reserved for wrap-up, also known as T&T (Treat and Talk Time). During T&T group members are offered a healthy snack and encouraged to take turns sharing their reactions to the session. Discussions focus on what members learned in the session and on how these experiences might be generalized to their life outside of the group.

The structure and topic for each session varies depending on the issues and needs of the individual members and the group as a whole. Therefore, aside from the initial session (Orientation) and the last session (Celebration), weekly sessions alternate between structured and nonstructured activities. Sessions 1–4, 6, 8, and 10 are highly structured through one or more activities focused on topics related to abuse. I use a variety of expressive arts, activities, role plays, and games in the structured sessions that are derived from my clinical experience and other resources. Sessions 5, 7, and 9 are process oriented and begin with nonstructured time in a playroom or a space with a variety of games, toys, art supplies, and activities from which group members are free to choose. The following outline includes examples of topics and activities for each of the sessions.

Session 1: Orientation

The initial session includes discussions about confidentiality, the purpose and structure of the group, and some basic ground rules (policies) such as no hitting, one person talks at a time, and confidentiality. I usually begin by thanking members for choosing to be a part of this group. I also state that everyone in the group has been abused but that this is not the only reason members were selected for this experience. I indicate that this group is about getting to know others, learning how to express feelings appropriately, and learning how to make positive choices. To assist children in getting acquainted with one another, I facilitate an icebreaker in which children take turns stating their name and something about themselves (favorite color, animal, or time of day). This type of go-around continues for approximately 15 to 20 minutes.

During the last half of the session, I use the term "group policies" to discuss rules and enlist the help of group members in making a list of rules for this group. This sets the tone by empowering children to co-construct the group experience. I record this information on a poster titled our "Group Declaration Banner" and provide a variety of art materials and encourage children to sign their names and decorate the Group Banner, which will be displayed during each group session and referred to whenever necessary to set limits. I closely monitor what policies members choose to adopt and make certain that we include rules to protect physical and emotional safety. I make certain that our declaration gives children the freedom to remain silent or pass on go-around activities, and I also emphasize boundary issues such as self-disclosure, confidentiality, and physical touch. In most cases, group members come up with policies that far surpass the rules or limits that I would enforce. Accordingly, I monitor the group to make certain that they don't make too many policies, or that the policies aren't too rigid. This group session ends with a final wrap-up T&T go-around.

Session 2: Awareness Activity

The relationship-building activity assists members in gaining insight and promotes healthy member interactions. Each member of the group creates an "identity collage," choosing four or five magazine images, phrases, or words that describe how the member sees her- or himself. Therapists are encouraged to select a wide range of magazines that support diversity and are developmentally appropriate. Once members have had the opportunity to share their collages, they are encouraged to reflect on how they have changed since the abuse. Group members are then encouraged to select at least one more item, word, or phrase that represents how they believe they have changed as a result of the abuse and how they feel about this change. These items are used to alter the

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existing collage, and group members are again given the opportunity to share their revised collages.

This activity gives group members an opportunity to self-reflect and engage in self-exploration regarding how the abuse has affected them. When processing this activity, it is important to discuss the multitude of intense feelings children associate with the abuse as well as the changes they have encountered. For example, the following remarks were shared in groups I facilitated with children who had been molested: "I am sad that I don't live with my mom and dad anymore." "I hate being a boy! My body does strange and dirty things." "I don't know if I will ever find a husband, because no boy will want me after they learn about what happened with my dad."

Session 3: Secrets and Touches

This session includes an activity specific to inappropriate and appropriate touching and safe and unsafe secrets. Because this activity is intended to help children learn how to both establish and adhere to appropriate physical boundaries and distinguish between safe and unsafe secrets, it is important to first define these concepts in developmentally appropriate terms to children. For example, I would explain: "A safe secret is not telling about something that won't harm anyone else, like keeping a surprise birthday party a secret. Whereas an unsafe secret is when something hurtful or dangerous is happening to you or someone else and you keep it a secret by not telling anyone." As a group activity, members are then encouraged to come up with lists of appropriate and inappropriate forms of touching and safe and unsafe secrets. This activity ends with members developing a plan about how to handle touching and secrets in a healthy manner in the future.

Session 4: Trust Activity

After the initial check-in, this session focuses on activities pertaining to trust. In the "trust walk," group members partner with one another; one member is blindfolded, and the other serves as a guide. The goal is to trust and communicate with one another as they move through a maze or a series of directions provided by the leader. The blindfolded member confronts issues of vulnerability, powerlessness, risk-taking, anxiety, and having to rely on others for support. The member who isn't blindfolded experiences an opportunity for leadership and mastery. Once members have processed their reactions to the trust walk experience, they are instructed to draw a picture or to create a list of people in their lives whom they can trust and to say why. Members are given the option of sharing their list with the rest of the group. At the end of this session, members are reminded that the next session will involve nondirective play, and they are ask to begin thinking about what they will choose and how they will spend their time together.

Session 5: Process Oriented

After the check-in, members are encouraged to make their own choices about what they would like to do during this session. I may offer a few general ideas about how members might play with one another. For example, I might say, "You can choose to play together (games, activities, role plays), or you may choose to play alone." I may point out some of the materials that are available, but for the most Part 1 remain nondirective. My role as leader in this session is to be a keen observer of group members' interactions and to see whether and how the children choose to engage with other members. I offer verbal and nonverbal encouragers and reflections as members make collective choices or individual ones about what to do in the session. The children often choose to play games or build sandtrays together, but some children use the time to explore the playroom or to create a drawing or painting on their own. The session ends with the traditional T&T time, and the children are offered an opportunity to reflect on their experiences in the group.

Session 6: Interpersonal Interaction Activity

By this point in the process, group cohesion usually is developed, and I focus on helping members address relationship dynamics and potential issues. We cover a variety of topics related to communication: using "I" messages, how to show respect for emotional and

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physical boundaries, how to ask for what one needs, and ways to appropriately express feelings. Games and structured activities specifically designed to address these topics include (a) the "talking, feeling, doing" game, (b) role plays, (c) puppet shows, (d) family drawings, and (e) the telephone game. We also might read from books, listen to music, and watch movies that address issues related to specific abuse and trauma.

Children who have been abused and traumatized often struggle with transitions (Gil, 2010; Terr, 2009), so I pay particular attention to the termination phase of the group. At the end of this sixth session, I remind members that we only have three more sessions until group ends and ask members to begin to think about how other groups in their lives have ended. I give examples of endings by talking about what it might be like when clubs or teams don't meet anymore or the end of the school year. In particular, we discuss how members have learned to say good-bye to others. We also talk about "good-bye rituals" that members have experienced in their families and communities, and I explain that we can decide how we want to say good-bye to each other and end this important experience. This session marks the beginning of the end of the group.

Session 7: Process Oriented

During this session children are offered another nondirective play experience. They typically read books, play with puppets, or utilize the art materials to create a picture or journal for themselves.

Session 8: Resilience Activity

The goal of this session is to assist members in developing a positive self-image. The focus is on helping children identify personal strengths and learn how to use their strengths to make healthy choices in the future. At the beginning of the session, I clarify what strengths are and encourage members to take a few moments to construct a list of at least four strengths they recognize in themselves. Examples have included: "I am a good listener." "I am a good friend." "I have learned how to show my anger without hitting someone or something." "I know how to say NO." Because self-esteem can be damaged by child abuse, the group counselor's assistance is especially important here. As a group we decide what we can do to creatively exhibit our strengths. Any number of activities and games can be used to accomplish this task, and I encourage members to create something. Sometimes they use art and construction materials to build kites, personal or family shields, personalized license plates, or T-shirts. Then members list their wants and needs in life, and we brainstorm ideas about how they can use their strengths to get their needs met and satisfy their desires in a healthy manner. I emphasize that they still have a choice about many aspects of their lives regardless of what people have said or done to them in the past. We talk about how their strengths can help them make healthy choices, about how to get their needs met in the future, and how to express their feelings and thoughts.

At the end of this session, we discuss the upcoming celebration session. We brainstorm ideas about what they want to do (activities, games, art, talk, sing, or dance). I inform group members that I will provide some sort of drink (usually juice) and at least one treat (usually fruit or popcorn).

Session 9: Process Oriented

Due to the power of group development and enhanced trust, members typically choose activities in which they verbally interact more during Session 9. For example, children often play board games and draw and share their pictures.

Session 10: Celebration

The last session is a celebration and a time to reminisce about the group experience, which includes members talking about what they have learned about themselves and others. The intent of this session is to achieve some sense of closure, and because group members have a hand in planning this session, the structure often varies. Final sessions have included, but are not limited to, the following. Younger children may want to create good-bye pictures that everyone in the group signs, create and

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act out a skit or role play, or play a game together. Older children and adolescents are more likely to appreciate a nondirective session in which group members have free time to reminisce about previous sessions and talk about their experiences in the group. On many occasions, older children and adolescents have brought refreshments to the last session and created personal journals out of art materials, which were then autographed or decorated by every member in the group as a memory of this experience. Regardless of the format, I request that all members share the following information: (a) what they have learned about their individual strengths and talents, (b) how they plan to continue making positive choices and building healthy relationships outside of group, and (c) their individual plans about how to take care of themselves.

Expected Group Outcomes

Children who have been abused deserve opportunities to express their thoughts, feelings, and overall reactions with others in a safe and constructive environment. After more than 20 years of experience facilitating groups with children who have been affected by abuse, I have come to believe that group counseling provides an ideal environment for these children to learn that they are not alone, to begin a healing process, and to learn how to establish a trusting and healthy relationship with other children, as well as with adults. In the group, children can break down the barriers of isolation, express their inner-most struggles, clarify misplaced blame, and feel more comfortable about interacting with others. In my view, the group atmosphere provides a deeper level of healing for children who have been affected by abuse. Enhanced interpersonal relationship skills, increased confidence and independence, and self-assurance are but a few of the outcomes exhibited by children who participate in these groups. Although assisting children in healing from abusive experiences can be complex and challenging, I encourage group counselors to pursue unique and creative ways to incorporate the therapeutic factors of group work in their interventions with children affected by abuse.

Recommended Resources

Resources that I found useful in designing this group include Gil (1991, 2006, 2010), Hindman (1993), Kleven (1997), Lowenstein (1999), Spinal-Robinson and Wickham (1992a, 1992b, 1993), Sweeney, Baggerly, and Ray (2014), and Terr (1990, 1991, 2008, 2009). For useful resources on the use of creative arts in groups and play therapy, see Gladding (2016), Kottman (2011), and Kottman and Meany-Walen (2016).

LO5

Developmental Themes of Adolescence

A detailed description of the unique needs of adolescents is beyond the scope of this book. For group leaders who work with adolescents, courses in the psychology of adolescents are essential. Reflecting on one's own adolescent experiences and perhaps reliving some of these experiences are also valuable means of preparing to counsel adolescents.

The adolescent period of life is characterized by searching for an identity and clarifying a system of values that will influence the course of one's life. Although adolescence presents stresses and conflicts, it is also a time of significant growth fueled by major cognitive advances, an increased orientation toward the social world, and physiological changes. Adolescents are increasingly interested in

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understanding how their experiences have shaped their current feelings and behaviors. One of the most important needs of this period is to experience successes that will lead to a sense of individuality and connectedness, which in turn lead to self-confidence and self-respect regarding their uniqueness and their sameness. Adolescents need opportunities to explore and understand the wide range of their feelings and to learn how to communicate with significant others in such a way that they can make their wants, feelings, thoughts, and beliefs known.

During the adolescent years, social relationships are of primary importance. Adolescents utilize these relationships to learn about self, the world, and others. This orientation toward the social world enhances their need for independence. However, adolescents and their parents sometimes mistakenly believe that this equates with a decreased need for parental time and attention. The most resilient adolescents have strong social skills and open, healthy relationships with their parents. This connection to family is crucial for long-term success.

Sources of Stress During Adolescence

Many adolescents experience tension between their lives at home and at school. They may feel stuck between these two worlds because the rules or expectations for these two systems do not match or are in disharmony, which can be a key source of stress. Adolescents from certain racial and cultural groups may experience additional stressors related to the challenges of racism, poverty, and other sociopolitical and social and environmental factors. In seeking their sense of self, adolescents often have difficulty relating to their parents, guardians, or grandparents. Other adolescents face family pressures that require that they work to help support the family. During this period, learning to use freedom and the dependence–independence struggle are central.

Adolescents are pressured to succeed and are expected to perform, frequently up to others' standards. They often feel a need for universal approval yet must learn to distinguish between living for others' approval and earning their own. Whether adolescents are trusted and given the freedom to make significant decisions is often based on cultural expectations. In Western cultures adolescents are encouraged to make decisions with the faith and support of caring adults, but they need guidelines and limits. Cultural conflicts between American-reared adolescents and their immigrant parents are often a significant source of stress. These adolescents may be functioning at a different level of assimilation or integration than their parents. Values, beliefs, and cultural practices can become the source of parent–child conflict.

Developmental Group Counseling With Adolescents

This brief sketch of the main currents of adolescent life highlights the need for developmentally appropriate counseling in this population. Generally, adolescents are more concerned with peer relationships than are younger children, and adolescents struggle with separation from parents and the development of self-identity. Peers become an important source of support, which makes groups a treatment of choice for adolescents (Shechtman, 2014). Group leaders need to understand the developmental needs of adolescents and have a cultural awareness of the

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community that they serve. In light of our society's rapidly changing demographics, group leaders need to make a concerted effort to address issues of diversity.

The opportunity to relate to peers who are experiencing very similar processes can be a healing experience. Akos, Hamm, Mack, and Dunaway (2007) illustrate the developmental importance of peer relationships during the early adolescent years and how group work provides a useful resource for members to explore their concerns with their peers. Young adolescents naturally look to their peers for affirmation and companionship, which makes group counseling particularly viable for this age group. Middle school counselors have the task of designing groups that can assist young adolescents in dealing with a variety of developmental tasks, providing an appropriate forum for promoting their personal and social development.

Group counseling is an ideal venue for engaging all of the strengths and struggles of adolescents. In addition, group leaders have an opportunity to combine personal themes with educational goals when developing the group structure. Through a positive group experience young people can learn about themselves, what they value, their beliefs, their relationships, and their choices. The group should have clearly defined goals, relevant themes, and a structure that will enable members to develop trust in the group. Their increasing orientation toward the social world blends beautifully with the group process. Isolation is decreased, social skills are gained, and the opportunity to understand psychological factors is provided.

LO6

Issues and Challenges in Leading Adolescent Groups

Motivating the adolescent to become an active group participant can be challenging. Group leaders need to clearly state the guidelines for conduct during sessions and gain members' acceptance. Creativity may be required to keep meetings moving in a meaningful direction. Gladding (2016) describes how creative group techniques such as music, movement, visual art, drama, play, and humor can be used as catalysts for interaction in high school groups. Creative techniques assist adolescents in expressing their emotions appropriately, behaving in different and healthier ways, and gaining insight into themselves and others. Coupling group work with creative techniques is a relatively attractive and familiar format for adolescents. However, regardless of how creative we are, there are definite challenges in facilitating adolescent groups. Some common challenges—developing trust and setting limits to self-disclosure—are discussed in the following sections.

Establishing Trust

The first task for an adolescent group facilitator is building rapport, which hinges on being yourself and avoiding pretense. To develop trusting relationships and to effectively work with young people, group leaders need to possess cultural sensitivity, understand current trends, and demonstrate respect for young people.

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Familiarize yourself with the members' subcultures, including their slang, style of speaking to one another, the types of music and entertainment media they enjoy, and their current modes of communication, including the many forms of social media now part of their lives. Group leaders would do well to have a general sense of the various ways adolescents are communicating with each other. However, you may find that adolescents will enjoy teaching you what you don't know. Having an opportunity to share their knowledge can provide a foundation for building trust.

A way to get some insight into the culture dimensions in a group is to begin a group session by asking members to bring in a song that describes their life theme or philosophy or by asking members to identify their favorite movie and then identify themes for discussion. This discussion can help group leaders understand the members' culture, and it creates some metaphors for a common language in a group. It is not necessary for you to talk like your adolescent clients by imitating their slang and manner of speaking, but it can be helpful in joining and understanding their world if you have some sense of their "culture." Understanding the world of young people does not mean that you become one of them. By trying too hard to be accepted, you may lose adolescents' trust and respect.

Deal directly, candidly, and openly with group members. They will know it if you are intimidated by them. If you don't have a clear sense of what you are doing, yet you pretend to be on their wave length, adolescents will detect this. However, being friendly, expressive, and warm goes a long way toward developing rapport with adolescents. In being personable and friendly you are not discounting therapeutic objectivity, but you are conveying acceptance, which tends to put young people at ease.

In an initial session, the discussion should include issues of confidentiality, group norms, ground rules, establishing boundaries to clarify appropriate and facilitative ways of interacting within the group, giving and receiving feedback, and suggestions for applications outside of the group. (For other topics that we typically explore during the early phase of a group as a way of generating trust, refer to the discussion in Chapter 6 on the initial stage.)

Know Your Comfort Zone With Self-Disclosure

Adolescents will ask you direct and personal questions. Sometimes this is a way of testing whether you subscribe to the ideas you are attempting to communicate to them. Adolescents often test group leaders to determine whether they mean what they have told them about the group. For example, adolescents will frequently ask the group leader questions such as "Have you ever experimented with drugs?" "Are your parents divorced?" " Are you married?" "Do you have a boyfriend or girlfriend?" "Do you have kids?" or "What are your thoughts about premarital sex?" Dealing with adolescents in an authentic manner requires some candor in responding, but this must be thoughtful. For example, a possible response to the question of drug use is: "That's a lose–lose question for me. If I say yes, then you can say, 'well, you turned out OK, so it's OK for me to do it.' If I say no, then you'll say 'well, you don't understand' and you'll discount what I say." How leaders respond to confrontational questions tells the members how much they can trust

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the group leaders. If this testing by adolescents is accepted in a nonjudgmental and nondefensive way, trust is enhanced and reluctance to participate in the group is reduced. Adolescents tend to respond well to leaders who appropriately share themselves with the group, displaying a caring attitude, enthusiasm and vitality, openness, and directness. If you genuinely respect and enjoy adolescents, you will typically be rewarded with a reciprocal respect.

Adolescents are quick to detect any traces of inauthenticity. A key leader task is to model congruence between what is said and what is actually done. However, this does not mean that a leader needs to disclose aspects of his or her private life on demand. A leader can model appropriate choices to resist pressure to disclose, just as he or she would do with adult groups. Many adolescents, especially those in the "system" or those living in difficult family situations, are in need of positive role models, and group leaders can provide this to their adolescent group members.

The group proposal "Teens Making a Change" describes strategies for setting up a group for young people that can be applied to both community and school settings. This is an excellent example of what can be accomplished when the purposes of a group are carefully considered. This group proposal also demonstrates the importance of understanding how to work in a system, whether in a school, a neighborhood, or the community.

GROUP PROPOSAL

Teens Making a Change (T-MAC): A Group for Preventing Teen Delinquency

This section is written from the perspective of Sheila D. Morris, PsyD. (For further information, contact Sheila at 1672 W. Avenue J., Suite 207, Lancaster, CA 93534; telephone: 661-951-4662; email: drsheila_2000@yahoo.com. A more comprehensive look at T-MAC is provided in the guidebook *Combating Teen Delinquency in an Apartment Setting Through Village Building* [Carter, 1998]).

Grassroots community-based groups for troubled youth can be considered the wave of the future. Based on a community psychology perspective, this group is designed as a preventive and intervention measure to help youth that live in an apartment complex. This setting is primarily composed of low socioeconomic status working-class African American and Latino families. The group serves as an additional support to families raising adolescents who may be susceptible to delinquent behaviors due to social, economic, and environmental factors. The group addresses traditional delinquent behaviors as well as teen dating, gangs, and racial differences and similarities. This is accomplished by incorporating several different components to increase awareness, promote dialogue, and instill pride and a sense of belonging. The original group design is community apartment-based, but it has been incorporated in juvenile detention and can be adapted and generalized to school settings and group homes.

Organizing the Group

The group is housed in an apartment complex where the youth live with their families, and it involves neighbors as well as community leaders, business professionals, and politicians. Group members range in ages from 12 to 19 and are self-referred. The group is composed of several different components to help youth become more productive in their community,

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school, and family. The group has adopted the motto "Hood life isn't the only life," and the group focuses on outings to areas outside their immediate living environment. The group meets weekly for 60 minutes with a group facilitator and parent/neighbor volunteer. Typically, the group is open-ended and ongoing, but this structure is flexible and is based on the needs of the community.

To adapt T-MAC to a school setting, contact the school administration to explore the proposal and to determine what benefit the group would have for the student members, the school, and the community at large. T-MAC members could be referred by teachers, guidance counselors, or parents, or be self-referred. The group could be composed of an entire classroom with participation of a teacher, counselor, or school psychologist or from various classes across grades. The group would be time-limited, with fieldtrips to expose students to locations outside their immediate community being one of the group's activities, thereby reinforcing the motto "Hood life isn't the only life."

The group agrees on rules for group behavior, consequences, and leadership. Confidentiality and safety issues are also discussed and honored. The facilitator explains the importance of parental involvement and the limits of confidentiality when it concerns serious threats of harm to self or others. The group addresses delinquent behaviors through open discussions. The structure includes viewing videotapes and other social media, interacting with guest speakers, and role plays. Several components have proved beneficial to the success of the group:

- *Discussion Groups.* Even in today's technological era, most teens are still searching for a caring ear and a way to express themselves in a healthy way. They are mostly concerned with and interested in subjects such as dating, sex, peer and family relations, careers, gangs, music, and fashion. Many inner-city youth do not have a forum in which to openly express their concerns in these areas, especially with a concerned and caring adult. Group members should be encouraged to present topics of interest.
- *Application to School Settings.* Peer interactions and relationships are important topics, especially among high school teens. The school is often the meeting ground for the beginnings of teen interpersonal relationships including gang activities. Youth exhibiting poor peer relationships, anger, and estrangement at home are all susceptible to gang involvement. T-MAC is a group designed for delinquency prevention and intervention, and in a school setting counselors would select the teens most at risk for delinquent behaviors.
- *Activities and Outings.* Outings play an important part for this group in that they help actualize opportunity. Teens from the neighborhood already know how to survive the social and environmental ills surrounding them. For many this way of life is all they know. Showing youth that the world is large and filled with great opportunities enhances their confidence and gives them a chance to explore new avenues. T-MAC outings have included a trip to the state capitol in Sacramento, hiking, going to museums and amusement parks, taking a trip to the snow in the mountains, going to stage plays, and a host of other outings and activities. Members also have participated in cleaning up graffiti and marching with political figures to protest crime and violence in the neighborhood. In more restrictive settings, T-MAC outings are virtual tours, as well as utilizing social media and the Internet. In school settings, fieldtrips could be prearranged and financially supported by business members and community leaders.
- *Fund-Raising.* T-MAC is a grassroots group. To fund outings and group activities, fund-raising events are employed. Group members present fund-raising ideas, which include bake sales, car washes, Internet raffles, and socials, to help realize the group's mission and motto. In addition, donations and sponsorships are sought from various sources.

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- *Guest Speakers.* Guest speakers on topics of gangs, building self-esteem, teen dating, violence, college, and career choices have played an important role in providing members with alternative perspectives and motivation, and they serve as role models and mentors. Speakers from the community, law enforcement, and business and entertainment sector can help to bridge the gap between the community, the school, and the individual.
- *Parental Involvement.* This is the most challenging aspect of the group. Often parents are not available to participate, and group members may not fully engage in the group process when their parents are present. Some parents have contributed by providing transportation, food preparation, and chaperoning.
- *Community Involvement.* Local business owners, community leaders, and politicians have contributed by providing donations, supplies, sponsorships, and other resources. T-MAC serves as a catalyst to bridge neighborhood and community leaders with school officials for the common cause of combating teen delinquency. This bridge helps transition teens from their neighborhood to the school and provides a more secure and stable sense of unity. Community leaders, business owners, and parent advocates could provide presentations and lead discussions in the group, further linking the school and the community.

Group Goals

The primary goal of the group is to end delinquent behaviors by providing alternative ways of dealing with urban stressors such as gangs, drugs, teen pregnancy, peer pressure, crime and violence, and poverty. In addition, it is expected that through group participation the worldview of the members can be expanded and they can find opportunities for success. To that end, this program focuses on these goals:

- Learning positive behaviors
- Linking school and community experiences
- Increasing social skills
- Increasing positive attitudes about self and others
- Increasing school functioning and learning
- Increasing community productiveness
- Alleviating neighborhood vandalism
- Building a sense of community belongingness
- Including as many influential and caring adults as possible to provide positive role modeling
- Providing community resources to aid families

Group Format

T-MAC was designed to meet the needs of a particular population. In keeping with the community psychology perspective, group members and the apartment complex community at large are directly involved in determining the topics and components of the group. T-MAC in school settings or detention facilities can be structured using the topics in this proposal. The 15 weekly sessions outlined here address gangs and gang involvement in the community setting. T-MAC topics in the classroom setting would likely address issues related to peer and relationship interactions, careers, skill building, and broadening members' global awareness through virtual travel. Each session begins by introducing the particular topic and ends by reviewing and incorporating new knowledge. These sessions can be adapted to fit a variety of groups or populations.

Session 1: Group Introduction

- The facilitator describes the purpose and focus of the group and reviews safety and confidentiality.
- Members introduce themselves, create group rules (such as one person talks at a time, respect toward other members, no use of profanity), and develop topics for group discussion.

Sessions 2 and 3: History of Gangs

- The facilitator provides a history of gangs from assorted readings.
- Members discuss the readings and relate this information to their own knowledge about gangs.
- Members pair up in dyads and discuss the readings.
- Dyads discuss their perceptions with the group.

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Sessions 4, 5, and 6: Personal Experience With Gangs

- Members discuss which identifiable gangs are in their neighborhood and what colors are not safe to wear.
- Members discuss personal experiences with gang involvement or near involvement.
- Members discuss their worries and fears.
- Members discuss how gangs affect the neighborhood, the schools, and the apartment complex.
- Members discuss personal affiliations with family members or friends.
- One member gives a presentation to the larger group about his or her experiences with gang members.
- Members answer questions from the larger group.

Sessions 7 and 8: Videotape Presentation

- Members view and discuss contents of an episode of *Beyond Scared Straight* or *Gangland.* News stories and Internet clips are also good resources to use in this segment.
- Facilitator summarizes the episode.
- Facilitator identifies alternatives to gang involvement.

Session 9: Making Connections

- Facilitator engages group members in discussing how the episode relates to what is happening in the neighborhood, school, or in their own lives.
- Members discuss alternatives and write different endings for selected characters.
- Members share and discuss the new characters with the group. For instance, they may be asked, "How is the new character's behavior different and how does this difference influence the story?"

Sessions 10 and 11: Making Changes

- Facilitator engages group members in discussing how their neighborhood or apartment complex would change if there were no gang members.
- Members answer questions such as "What positive alternatives for youth could replace gangs?" and "How could gangs change to promote a positive image?"
- Members map out and visualize their neighborhood without gangs.

Session 12: Using Role Plays

- Facilitator provides scenarios for role plays.
- Members create role plays for what they can do if they are approached by gang members or if they are having a bad experience with a peer.
- Members alternate between providing scenarios and participating in role plays.
- Members pair up to write about their experiences and share them with group members.

Sessions 13, 14, and 15: Alternatives

- Guest speaker presents personal experience with gangs and how he or she overcame gang life.
- Facilitator engages group in discussing and summarizing topics about gangs.
- Facilitator helps to identify new knowledge and ways to implement alternative coping strategies to deal with gangs.
- Members discuss new knowledge and alternatives to gang involvement.
- Members discuss their learning and where to go from here.
- Members continue implementing plans for change.

Group Outcomes

Although there are no formal outcome measures for this group, anecdotal reports indicate that group members gained a sense of self-improvement from having a safe place to share normal adolescent developmental issues. They also acquired adaptive coping skills to

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deal with social and environmental ills plaguing their neighborhood.

As part of the group process, members are encouraged to describe what they are learning and how the group is affecting them. As termination of the group approaches, the members are asked to write about the personal benefits of the experience. One 12-year-old African American boy writes, "The benefits of being in the T-MAC club is having fun, solving problems, and doing lots of activities." According to a 16-year-old Latina, "The benefit of being in T-MAC is that we have experiences that make us think about what we are seeing and doing. It helps me see where I want to go. I also enjoy being in the club because of the activities. Instead of drugs and violence, we go places." These subjective accounts indicate generally positive experiences by group members. Positive benefits to the apartment complex include a lower incidence of vandalism and loitering and a reduction in intentional property destruction. The benefit for schools may include fewer disciplinary actions against T-MAC members and more days present.

Developing and facilitating T-MAC has proved to be challenging as well as rewarding. Designing and generalizing the group concepts to extend to other systems such as schools and detention facilities is an ongoing process. Over a period of years, I have sustained a sense of excitement and satisfaction by helping teens through this transitional developmental time. Providing youth with opportunities for discovering new experiences and helping them face and work through difficult personal issues are among the benefits of designing this group. I have learned many valuable lessons regarding the adolescent world, intervention strategies for preventing delinquency, how to access community resources, and how to interact effectively with business, political, school, and community leaders. Moreover, the ideology of apartment-based prevention and intervention to combat teen delinquency remains an innovative concept. A future study measuring the effectiveness of such a group would be beneficial to the advancement of apartment-based prevention and community psychology.

LO7

Helping Adolescents Deal With Anger and Conflict

As counselors, we know that metal detectors and increased law enforcement presence will not solve the dilemma schools face in light of the increase in the frequency and intensity of violence. Helping young people learn to be aware of and manage anger and conflict can help prevent violent actions. Conflict management groups and groups designed to teach adolescents appropriate ways to express and deal with their anger are excellent means of prevention, and these groups can be most useful in the school environment. These groups are aimed at learning effective ways to deal with anger through interpersonal skills development, problem solving, and learning adaptive self-talk.

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A High School Anger Management Group

This section is written from the perspective of Jason Sonnier, who set up and facilitated an anger management group for adolescents at Hamilton High School in Anza, California. (For further information, contact Jason by email: jsonnier@hemetusd.k12.ca.us.)

As a high school counselor, I am in a position to do one-on-one counseling as well as run groups for adolescents on anger management and violence prevention, alcohol and drug awareness and intervention, and other topics as needed. High school counselors will all agree that there never seems to be enough time in the day to get to all of the various responsibilities of the job. In my first year as a school counselor I found that group counseling can be an excellent way to provide services to many students and save valuable time.

Facilitating a group for adolescents for the first time was an intimidating, yet rewarding, experience. I was asked by a student if we could start an anger management group because she was court-ordered to attend counseling and there were no alternatives for her in our small, rural community. Although inexperienced and nervous, I agreed and set up the group. This was my first attempt at implementing a high school anger management group.

Organizing the Group

The student assisted me in recruiting participants for the group. Other students were referred based on administrative action for incidents of violent behavior. In all there were seven students, four males and three females. Four group members were voluntary participants, and three (all males) were referred by the administration. The group was designed to last eight sessions running 1 hour twice a week for 4 weeks. Days chosen were Mondays and Thursdays, with alternating times to limit time missed in each class.

Group Goals

The goals for participants in this anger management group were as follows:

- Become aware of and challenge their own beliefs regarding conflict and violence
- Be able to identify situations and behaviors that lead to violence and conflict
- Understand and identify personal triggers that lead to conflict
- Become conscious of their nonproductive approaches to conflict and the alternatives they have in dealing with certain situations
- Learn skills in communication, negotiation, mediation, violence avoidance, and stress management
- Be able to identify and avoid certain people, places, and situations that will likely lead to conflict

Group Format

Session 1: Group Introduction

- Explain purpose of the group.
- Facilitator and members are introduced to each other.
- Discuss rules of groups with emphasis on confidentiality.
- Explore group members' attitudes toward aggression and violence.

Session 2: Personal Triggers

- Participants tell of how they or their family have been affected by violence.
- Discuss situations that make them angry and how they react.
- Reflect on why they react the way they do and how they learned this.
- Begin to learn to focus on themselves first and identify in advance what gets them angry.

Session 3: Avoiding Conflict and Violence

- Discuss situations likely to lead to conflict and ways to avoid them.
- Students share what strategies have worked for them or others.
- Learn techniques to avoid and to get out of unhealthy situations.
- Students practice techniques with each other in role-play activity.

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Session 4: Personal Values and Goals

- Consider family values and personal goals in relation to values, goals, and beliefs of others around them.
- Discuss what values and goals are most important in their lives and how they plan to meet those goals.
- Discuss how anger, violence, and avoidable conflict will prevent them from reaching certain goals in their lives.

Session 5: Improving Communication Skills

- Reflect on how communication problems can lead to conflicts.
- Students identify which communication problems they need to work on.
- Discuss how listening and speaking more carefully can help to avoid conflict.
- Participants learn and practice effective communication techniques.

Session 6: Peer Relationships

- Consider how peer pressure contributes to unhealthy behaviors.
- Review goals discussed in Session 4 and determine whether current peers and friends are interfering with reaching those goals.
- Challenge students to choose friends and groups that will support them in their effort to avoid violence and conflict.
- Identify ways to make good decisions about whom to associate with.

Session 7: Negotiation and Mediation

- Learn and practice basic steps in negotiation.
- Understand when and how to seek out and use mediation.
- Students share how negotiation or mediation worked for them or others.

Session 8: Final Group Session

- Identify areas in their lives that cause the most stress.
- Discuss stress management techniques and coping strategies.
- Students talk about their feelings for the group and what they will work on to reduce conflict and violence in their lives.

Group Outcomes

Although this particular group started out a bit rocky, it ended smoothly. In the beginning I struggled to get two of the members to talk at all, and many of the others were preoccupied with bragging about their violent incidents and asserting their toughness. By the fourth session one of the disruptive students was removed from the group by the administration, and the rest of the members then settled down. As I got past my initial fears and anxiety and began to disclose my own experiences, I found that the students really started to open up. From the first session of just trying to keep order to the last few sessions of good deep philosophical discussions, I certainly learned a great deal about my students and myself. Specifically, I learned that, as the group facilitator, I will not have all of the answers, and that this is acceptable. The group may take an unintended path, which can be of benefit to the members. More important, I learned that it is really the students that help each other, as they will often listen to and trust their peers more than an adult.

The biggest problem I encountered was the tendency of my students to get off track. Even though there were only seven adolescent participants, I had to struggle to keep them on topic, several times each session. So if only one person is facilitating the group, I recommend keeping it small, at least four but no more than eight students. For next time I will try to bring in more exercises and real world examples that will keep the students focused and interested on the day's topic. Of course, it would help if all participants were voluntary or self-referred, but this is not likely in a high school setting. Although it was often tough having students who did not really want to be in the group, I believe they did learn from the other members and left with a new insight into themselves. Some students opened up more readily than others, which helped the rest of the group feel comfortable to eventually share their stories. Many members gave each other feedback regarding ways of dealing with certain situations differently in the

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future. This group gave students a chance to look at themselves and question their actions and how they may want to change certain behaviors. For some, just knowing that other students have dealt with the same kinds of anger issues within their families was a bonding experience. With the feedback from fellow group members, students have a starting point toward change and a network of support.

Reflections and Afterthoughts

Looking back with a few more years of experience, I can see how I have grown in my ability and approach to facilitate a productive and meaningful group counseling experience. I have learned to be more flexible and responsive to what the students want to discuss. I try not to forcefully lead in one rigid direction, and I avoid the irrational belief that I must cover a certain topic in depth or the time was wasted. I have come to realize that no groups will unfold in the same manner. Some are more successful than others, and some seem to meander aimlessly. In my first few groups, I was more likely to provide the "answers" members were looking for. Now I enjoy watching the students self-reflect and find ways to support each other and come up with their own solutions. They have the responsibility of making choices, accepting the consequences of their decisions, and generating a plan to change. As they help each other through this process, strong ties are built among the students, and they have a feeling of empowerment and self-control, the lack of which brought them to the group in the first place.

Groups in College Counseling Centers

A common complaint we hear is that it is easy to feel isolated on a university campus. With the emphasis on intellectual development, students often feel that relatively little attention is paid to their personal development. For many students, the college experience is stressful not only academically but in their personal lives as well. A diversity of special needs on the college campus can be explored through a group experience. In a group setting students can formulate goals, discuss common concerns, explore factors that are causing them difficulties in interpersonal relating, and identify the internal blocks impeding the full utilization of their capabilities. By dealing with their personal problems, students are able to free themselves of certain emotional blocks to learning and can become far better students, approaching their studies with a sense of enthusiasm and commitment.

College and university counseling centers often have limited resources with which to address a multitude of issues. Although the value of group work is evident to practitioners in college counseling centers, Parcover, Dunton, Gehlert, and Mitchell (2006) find it is often difficult to recruit members due to client reluctance to participating in a group, staff reluctance to promote groups as a treatment of choice, and ineffective group formats and poor marketing of these groups.

Common Topics in College Groups

Time-limited groups with structured topics or themes are most commonly offered in university counseling centers. College counselors frequently experience difficulty

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promoting open-ended process groups, personal-growth groups, and groups without a specific theme. Instead, groups are most often designed to address an emerging need or assist clients with specific concerns. On any college campus a number of students are likely to be victims of violence, rape, sexual abuse, sexual harassment, racism, or discrimination. The themes that emerge from a group often reflect the unique composition of that group. A good place to begin designing a group is to conduct a needs survey on the college campus.

A variety of psychoeducational, theme-oriented, and counseling groups are frequently offered at college and university counseling centers. Effective theme groups are time-limited and involve specific change strategies that guide group participants through a learning process. A few examples include career development and career planning groups, anxiety-management groups, stress-management groups, grief groups, cultural identity groups, nontraditional age student groups, groups for those with relationship concerns, groups dealing with body image, group addressing trauma, self-esteem groups, groups for survivors of childhood sexual abuse, and personal identity groups.

These groups typically last from 6 to 16 weeks and are aimed at meeting a variety of special needs by combining both therapeutic and educational components. The scope of the topics for structured groups and for theme groups is limited only by the needs of the population, the creativity of the counselor, and the effort it takes to promote the group. Theme groups, psychoeducational groups, and structured groups in college counseling centers are a cost-effective approach to meeting the needs of a diverse range of college students.

Some Groups for College Students

A wide range of groups can be found at college and university counseling centers. As an internship placement, you might facilitate or colead a group through the college counseling center. In *Group Work and Outreach Plans for College Counselors*, Finch and Marshall (2011) review a variety of psychoeducational and counseling groups structured around specific concerns of college and university students. Following are three examples of these groups:

- *Interpersonal Process Groups in College and University Settings* (Reese, 2011). There is a clear need for college and university groups that focus on relationships and interpersonal processes. College students are at a unique developmental stage, and interpersonal groups can be most useful in assisting them in clarifying their identity and broadening the scope of their relationships. This 10-week group is described in terms of the stages of the group's development.
- *Supporting Students of Color on Campus* (Steen, Griffin, & Shi, 2011). Many students of color and students from low-income families do not remain in college beyond the first year because of limited academic and personal supports. Steen and colleagues describe a group counseling program for students of color, first-generation college students, and students from impoverished backgrounds that helps them develop strategies for coping with the personal and academic challenges of the college experience.
- *Support Groups for Gay and Lesbian Students* (Thomas & Hard, 2011). Gay and lesbian college students can benefit from participating in a support group that

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provides participants with opportunities to share their problems in coping with discrimination. Group work can be a powerful vehicle contributing to positive identity development and reduced alienation. The affirmation that members receive in the group helps to counteract family, community, and spiritual difficulties members face outside of the group. This 13-week group includes psychoeducational aspects, but it is primarily designed as a developmental and counseling group.

Group work offers promise for a broad spectrum of college and university students. These groups can assist students who are coping with academic difficulties, but they also provide a supportive climate in which students can acquire insights and skills in managing the personal and social dimensions of their lives. Groups enable people to deal with life transitions and challenges such as forming new relationships, coping with struggles pertaining to self-identity, and dealing with oppression. Group counseling is an effective and efficient route to meeting the developmental needs of college students (Whittingham, 2014).

Points to Remember

Groups in School Settings

Groups Designed for School Settings

Here are some key points in designing and conducting groups for children, adolescents, and college students in school settings:

- As a prerequisite to the effective facilitation of groups for children or adolescents, it is essential to acquire a working knowledge of the developmental needs of those who will be in your group.
- In designing a group in schools or agencies, strive to develop collaborative relationships with agency directors, principals, teachers, and colleagues.
- It is essential to understand the laws of your state regarding minors and the policies of the agency where you work.
- It is a good practice to obtain written permission of parents or guardians for group members who are under the age of 18.
- Confidentiality is particularly important in groups with children and adolescents. Communicate with young people about the importance of keeping confidences.
- Not all students are ready for group participation in a school setting. You need to have clear criteria regarding who can benefit from involvement in a group.
- Having some structure is particularly important in groups with children or adolescents.
- Give thought to helpful methods of evaluating the outcomes of your groups with children or adolescents.
- Groups in the schools can combine personal themes with psychoeducational goals.
- It is wise to conduct a needs assessment in a school setting to identify particular kinds of groups that will be most useful.
- Authenticity and warmth on the part of the group leaders are crucial to group success.
- Role-playing techniques can be used creatively in groups for both children and adolescents.

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- A group experience can provide ways for college students to establish connections with other students and to increase their sense of belongingness.
- Theme-oriented groups are especially appropriate for college and university students because they have a clearly defined purpose and are structured with time-limited change strategies.
- College students in a group can explore factors that are causing them difficulties in interpersonal relating. By addressing their personal problems, students are often able to resolve emotional blocks to learning and can improve their academic performance.

Exercises

In-Class Activities

1. **Design a Group for Children or Adolescents.** Break up into small groups in the classroom and work collaboratively to design different kinds of groups for children or adolescents. Each of the subgroups can work on a different kind of group. Identify the specific type of group you would be interested in forming, and brainstorm possible steps for establishing this group. In developing your proposal, consider factors such as type of group, goals and purposes, strategies for recruiting members, format and structure of the group, and methods for evaluating outcomes.
2. **Guest Speaker.** Invite a therapist who conducts groups with children (or adolescents) to your class to discuss how he or she sets up such a group. The speaker could share both the challenges in doing group work with children or adolescents and the unique benefits of group participation.
3. **Review the T-MAC Group Concept.** Review the teens making a change group (T-MAC). If you were the director of an agency, or a school principal, what kind of response would you have toward funding and launching this group in your own setting?
4. **Evaluate the Group Proposals.** In small groups critique the group proposals presented in this chapter. As you review these proposals, pay particular attention to the multicultural dimensions of each proposal. What aspects of each proposal would you want to incorporate in one of your group proposals? What are some of the advantages of using a group format for the kinds of problems explored in each group? Of all the proposals presented in this chapter, which proposal did you find to be the most unusual and why?
5. **Groups Offered at Your University Counseling Center.** Visit the counseling center at your university or college and inquire about specific kinds of groups that are available. Might you be interested in becoming a member of any of these groups?
6. **Community Programs.** Some class members can visit a school or a community agency where groups are available for children or adolescents. Find out what types of groups are offered, the structure of these groups, and the reactions of the members. Present what you find to your class.

MindTap for Counseling

Additional resources can be found on CengageBrain.com and by logging into the MindTap course created by your professor. There you will find a variety of study tools and useful resources that include quizzes, videos, interactive exercises, and more.

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